

Chicago Tribune



QUESTIONS? CALL 1-800-TRIBUNE

THURSDAY, APRIL 24, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Durbin won't seek 6th term



Sen. Dick Durbin, D-Ill., greets people inside the Lyndon B. Johnson Room at the U.S. Capitol on Feb. 12. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Long-serving senator, who turned 80 years old in November, says it's time to 'pass the torch,' setting off state Democrats angling to run for position

By Rick Pearson
Chicago Tribune

Dick Durbin, whose tenure as one of Illinois' longest-serving U.S. senators has also been a testament to the power of seniority in the chamber, announced Wednesday he will not seek a sixth term next year, setting up a scramble among potential successors vying for a politically coveted six-year term.

"The decision of whether to run for reelection has not been easy. I truly love the job of being a United States senator. But in my heart, I know it's time to pass the torch. So, I am announcing today that I will

not be seeking reelection at the end of my term," Durbin said in a video.

"Right now, the challenges facing our country are historic and unprecedented," Durbin said. "The threats to our democracy and way of life are very real, and I can assure you that I will do everything in my power to fight for Illinois and the future of our country every day of my remaining time in the Senate."

With Durbin's announcement setting off a potential domino effect among Illinois Democratic members of Congress and others angling to run for his Senate seat,

Turn to Durbin, Page 4

WHAT'S NEXT: With his announcement that he will not seek reelection next year, U.S. Sen. Dick Durbin set into motion an upheaval of Democratic politics involving current officeholders looking at the potential risks and rewards of seeking a coveted Senate seat. **Chicagoland, Page 4**

■ Despite reports that she won't seek reelection, U.S. Rep. Jan Schakowsky indicates that she's still unsure about her future. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

HIGHLAND PARK PARADE SHOOTING

Dreams destroyed by 'violent tantrum'

Terror recounted as Crimo skips hearing

By Robert McCoppin
Chicago Tribune

Highland Park parade shooter Robert Crimo III skipped his sentencing hearing Wednesday, opting to stay in the Lake County Jail instead of listening to the trauma he inflicted upon an entire community.

If he had attended the proceeding, he would have learned about the consequences of his violent actions, about the seven spectators he killed, the four dozen people he injured and the countless others he has scarred in a different way. He would know about the parents who are needed, the spouses who are missed, the people who made this world a happier place.

"You murdered my soulmate, my wife of 33 years, and the mother of my only child," Bruce Sundheim wrote of his wife, Jacki Sundheim, in a statement read during the hearing. "All the plans, hopes and dreams we had together were destroyed by your violent tantrum."

Survivor after survivor spoke, offering 18 impact statements that detailed their acute personal grief and anguish. And in sharing the shooting's

Turn to Hearing, Page 2



A firefighter sheds tears as he leaves Stroger Hospital to prepare for the procession to the Cook County medical examiner's office to honor Chicago Fire Capt. David Meyer, who died after battling a West Side garage fire on Wednesday. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Firefighter was family's 'rock'

Captain dies after roof collapses while battling garage blaze in the city's Austin neighborhood

By Carolyn Stein, Andrew Carter and Nell Salzman
Chicago Tribune

The emergency call came in at 4:03 Wednesday morning, with a report of a fire in the 1200 block of North Pine Avenue in the Austin neighborhood on the West Side. The blaze was less

than 2 miles north of the Chicago Fire Department station known as Engine 96/Truck 29 — the station where David Meyer had worked his way up to captain, where he was in his 29th year as a Chicago firefighter.

He and his colleagues rushed into the truck and to the scene. The fire had spread to the garage at 5505 W. Crystal St. Fifteen

minutes after the call came in, though, they had the fire extinguished. It had to seem, for a brief moment, like a routine early-morning call, and the responders "were outside the garage," Commissioner Annette Nance-Holt said later, "starting salvage and overhaul."

That's when the garage collapsed. Meyer, working in the midst of it all, suffered inju-



Meyer

ries that prompted what Nance-Holt described as a "mayday alarm." He was transported to Stroger Hospital and by 11:21 a.m., some of his fellow firefighters could be seen with tears in their eyes as they walked out of the hospital, mourning the death of one of their own.

Meyer, who joined the department in October 1996, was 54.

Turn to Meyer, Page 5

STEVE McMICHAEL 1957-2025



ZBIGNIEW BZDAK/CHICAGO TRIBUNE 2019

Forever a favorite, forever 'Mongo'

Steve McMichael, the Hall of Fame defensive tackle who was one of the beloved leaders and most colorful characters of the 1985 Chicago Bears, died Wednesday after a lengthy battle with ALS. **Chicago Sports**

■ Blink-182, Green Day and Weezer headline at Riot Fest. **Arts & Living**

POPE FRANCIS 1936-2025

In Chicago, a Mass for 'the people's pope'

By Jonathan Bullington
Chicago Tribune

Hundreds of people filled the pews inside Chicago's Holy Name Cathedral on a rainy Wednesday morning for a memorial Mass to Pope Francis, the 88-year-old pontiff remembered for a groundbreaking and unpretentious papacy.

Cardinal Blase Cupich, archbishop of Chicago, presided over the service. Elevated to the College of Cardinals in 2016, Cupich is scheduled to head to Rome this week for Francis' funeral. Eventually, he and his fellow cardinals will convene to

select Francis' successor.

"It was difficult to get through the ceremony today," Cupich told reporters after the service. "But now we move ahead, and that's the way (Francis) would want us to be. He always looked on what's next, because, as he said, Jesus is always doing something new."

Linda Fowlkes arrived at the historic cathedral an hour before the service's 10 a.m. start time. Despite being raised Baptist, the 63-year-old Southwest Side resident said she felt compelled to pay her respects to the pope, who died Monday at his residence, one day after he delivered an Easter

Sunday blessing to thousands gathered in St. Peter's Square and nearly a month after he was discharged from Rome's Gemelli Hospital, where he spent 38 days battling a near-fatal case of pneumonia in both lungs.

"He was the people's pope," Fowlkes said. "He reached out to the world."

Seated several rows back, Bucktown resident Melissa Velarde, 45, said she admired Francis' leadership and felt a special connection to the Argentinian-born pope because she is originally from Peru.

Turn to Pope, Page 2

"He was someone who lived what he taught. He didn't just say we're going to reach people in the margins, he did that. He tried to build a church that was inclusive of everyone." — *Kevin Copp, who attended the memorial Mass*

